

“Variations in Translating Complex Psychopedagogical Terminology: A Comparative Analysis from English to Arabic”

A study presented by :

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Summary

This study examines the challenges involved in translating complex psychopedagogical terminology from English into Arabic. Because psychopedagogy draws upon concepts from psychology, education, and cognitive science, its terminology is often abstract, culturally embedded, and theoretically debated even in its source language. These characteristics lead to inconsistencies and ambiguities in Arabic translations, causing confusion in educational contexts and academic discourse. By applying a comparative analysis, this research identifies patterns of variation and highlights the need for standardization, interdisciplinary collaboration, and culturally sensitive translation strategies. Such efforts can improve terminological consistency, facilitate clearer educational communication, and promote effective knowledge transfer across cultures.

Keywords: psychopedagogy, terminology translation, Arabic, comparative analysis, standardization, intercultural communication

Résumé

Cette étude examine les défis liés à la traduction de la terminologie psychopédagogique complexe de l'anglais vers l'arabe. Étant donné que la psychopédagogie puise ses concepts dans la psychologie, l'éducation et les sciences cognitives, sa terminologie est souvent abstraite, culturellement ancrée et théoriquement débattue même dans

la langue source. Ces caractéristiques entraînent des incohérences et des ambiguïtés dans les traductions arabes, ce qui provoque une confusion dans les contextes éducatifs et dans le discours académique. En appliquant une analyse comparative, cette recherche identifie des schémas de variation et souligne la nécessité d'une normalisation, d'une collaboration interdisciplinaire et de stratégies de traduction sensibles aux contextes culturels. De tels efforts peuvent améliorer la cohérence terminologique, faciliter une communication éducative plus claire et promouvoir un transfert de connaissances efficace entre les cultures.

Mots-clés : psychopédagogie, traduction terminologique, arabe, analyse comparative, normalisation, communication interculturelle.

Introduction

The translation of specialized terminology presents a persistent challenge in the field of translation studies, particularly when dealing with complex and multidimensional disciplines such as **psychopedagogy**. As an interdisciplinary field that merges concepts from psychology, education, and cognitive science, psychopedagogy generates terminologies that are often deeply rooted in cultural, theoretical, and institutional frameworks. Consequently, their accurate and context-sensitive translation requires not only linguistic competence but also a profound understanding of the underlying conceptual structures.

This study aims to examine the **varieties and inconsistencies** in the translation of selected psychopedagogical terms from English into Arabic. The motivation for choosing this topic stems from observed disparities in the Arabic renditions of core terms such as *scaffolding*, *metacognition*, *cognitive load*, *transfer of learning*, and *zone of proximal development*. These variations often lead to ambiguity in academic discourse, misinterpretation in teaching materials, and inconsistencies in knowledge transfer between cultures.

The **main objective** of this research is to explore how these terminological differences emerge, to classify the types of translation strategies used, and to evaluate their adequacy in capturing both the denotative and connotative meanings of the original terms. Through a **comparative method**, this study analyzes parallel texts, translated

manuals, and pedagogical literature to identify how the same English terms are rendered across different Arabic contexts—educational, psychological, or institutional.

The **problematic** at the heart of this research lies in the tension between the need for terminological consistency and the challenges of cultural and epistemological equivalence. Unlike purely technical terms, psychopedagogical concepts are often abstract, culturally loaded, and subject to theoretical debate—even in the source language. Their translation, therefore, involves both **linguistic transfer** and **epistemological negotiation**.

The study is guided by the following **hypotheses**:

First, there is **no standardized Arabic translation** for several key psychopedagogical terms, leading to terminological fragmentation across Arabic educational literature.

Second, the **variety in translation** reflects deeper epistemological and cultural divergences, rather than mere linguistic variance.

Third, the most effective translations are those that strike a balance between **conceptual fidelity** and **communicative clarity**, often using explication or borrowing rather than literal translation.

By identifying and analyzing these patterns, this research hopes to contribute to both **terminological harmonization** and **pedagogical clarity** in Arabic academic and educational contexts.

Translation as a Science:

Translation is not merely an art or a skill but also a science that involves systematic principles, empirical research, and theoretical frameworks to analyze and reproduce meaning across languages with accuracy and consistency. As a scientific discipline, translation studies examine linguistic structures, cognitive processes, and sociocultural factors that influence cross-language communication. However, the challenges in Specialized Translation might vary as follow. First of al Terminological Consistency – Ensuring the same

term is used uniformly (e.g., "myocardial infarction" vs. "heart attack"). Then Cultural Adaptation – Legal and medical systems vary across countries (e.g., "common law" vs. "civil law"). Finally, Neologisms and Evolving Terms – Keeping up with new terminology (e.g., "blockchain" in fintech). The growing complexity of global interactions has highlighted the importance of understanding translation as both a professional practice and an academic field, where issues of equivalence, fidelity, cultural mediation, and ethics are systematically investigated (Munday, 2016).

Specialized Translation

Specialized translation of documents in a particular discipline which involve in-depth knowledge of the subject and its terminology is known as specialized translation. Specialized translation deals with technical, scientific, legal, medical, or professional content, as opposed to general translation.

Specialised translation handles professional, scientific, technical, legal, medical, or other specialised content that distinguishes it from general translation. (Cabr , 1999) Specialised translation demands a great level of accuracy coupled with familiarity with some terminology.

Fundamental Components of Skilled Translation:

Translators need to have knowledge in the specific fields that they translate for, be it but not limited to legal reports, medical records, or technical manuals. Term precision is important, with the right application of specialized terms such as "neuroplasticity" in psychological jargon or "torsion" in engineering terminology. Good research skills are necessary so that translators can verify terms by using glossaries, comparative texts, and consultations with the subject matter experts on the specific subjects. The ability to adapt to the target audience is of the utmost importance, demanding that translators modify their language to fit both experts and non-experts alike, as can be seen in the distinction between an academic medical paper and a patient's informational brochure. Descriptive Translation Studies (DTS) is a major turn in translation theory by implementing a descriptive approach rather than a prescriptive one.

It is concerned with analyzing the processes of translation

production and reception in various contexts, more than with the application of strict criteria regarding what constitutes a "correct" translation. This theory model varies from conventional dependence on the source text, instead pursuing an examination of functional and cultural contexts, such as socio-historical factors, translation conventions, and power relationships. DTS uses empirical approaches like case studies, corpus studies, and comparative methods to research pragmatic translation practice in real contexts, thus highlighting the significance and influence of translated texts in their target cultures. The Manipulation School's emphasis on ideological mediation, Even-Zohar's polysystem theory situating translation in dynamic literary systems, and Toury's translation norms differentiating between acceptability and adequacy are significant theoretical developments. While DTS has been involved in translation studies that looks at real translations. It analyzes and describes the translations instead of describing how to translate. DTS came from the polysystem theory and Manipulation School. These theories were mainly developed by scholars such as Gideon Toury, and Theo Hermans.

The Definition of Translation in terminology

The process of transferring a source text (ST) into a target text (TT) with the aim of preserving meaning, function, and effect within the confines of the target language and its cultural context is referred to as translation. This process, involves the transfer of linguistic signs from one language system into another. (Jakobson, 1959)

Differences Between Terminological and Lexicological Definitions

This basic difference in linguistic research is caused by lexicological and terminological differences, and it indicates various approaches to conceiving and organizing language units. Lexicology, Jackson states, to a great extent entails the close examination of the lexicon within a general language, including semantic relations, historical development, and contextual polysemy, as can be seen from standard descriptive dictionaries. Conversely, when using Cabre's model, terminology is thought of as residing in the specific focus on domain-specific terms that are characterized by their conceptual specificity, systematic organization, and functional univocity within professional

specialized discourse. The two approaches are manifested in this difference: lexicology is predominantly descriptive in manner, noting language in its natural variation, whereas terminology employs prescriptive methods of standardizing meanings for accurate technical communication (Sager C, 1990). In translation practice, the demand for terminological precision in specialized fields necessitates strict conceptual pairing, whereas general language translation provides greater semantic latitude; the pragmatic consequences of the distinction are therefore particularly evident. The conceptual difference indicates the necessity for language professionals to knowingly alternate between these paradigms in accordance with context requirements. In this way, it guarantees linguistic accuracy in day-to-day communication and accuracy in specialized fields. Being a translation as a semiotic process, it makes use of Charles Sanders Peirce's triadic model of signs comprising three basic components: the representament (or sign-vehicle), the object (or referent), and the interpretant (or meaning as interpreted by the receiver). They are involved in dynamic interaction in the translation process to facilitate the transfer of meaning between various linguistic and cultural paradigms, as elaborated below with theory support:

1. The shape of the sign, represents

Combining lexicon, syntax, and discourse aspects, the source text (ST) constitutes the initial sign-vehicle. Maintaining semiotic relations, this shape in translation is converted to target language signals (Gorle, 1994). As an example, managing the lexical structure of the ST is essential in order to ensure the rhetorical effect in the target text (TT) when translating a metaphor ("time is a thief").

2. Object, also known as referent or idea

The object is the physical thing or abstract concept that is represented by a symbol. Translation must bridge conceptual and cultural gaps, as can be seen in English translation of culture-specific expressions like "malicious pleasure." Eco (2001) emphasizes that objects are interpreted using culturally embedded knowledge structures, and not fixed meanings.

3. Receiver interpretation is the meaning created by the receiver.

The interpretant indicates the dynamic interpretation of TT readers in line with target-culture norms. Tourys's theory (1995) comes close to this by stipulating that translations assign the greatest priority to acceptability (reader-oriented meaning) at the expense of adequacy (ST fidelity). Subtitling humor, for instance, (e.g., replacing a French pun with an English one) responds to the interpretants cultural frame.

Interdependence in Interpretation

The triadic process functions synergistically: the translator rebuilds the STs representamen-object (e.g., technical terminology in an expert report) for the TTs interpretant (e.g., a doctor reading the translated report). Process breakdown like misunderstanding of a legal concept ("force majeure") risks semiotic false equivalence (Stecconi, 2004).

The terminology of educational psychology consists of specialist terminology linking psychological theory and educational practice, emphasizing the cognitive, affective, and social processes involved in learning and teaching. The concept of "metacognition" (Flavell, 1979) as control and awareness of one's own cognitive processes affects strategies such as learning monitoring and self-questioning that are at the heart of this vocabulary. Likewise, "scaffolding" (Wood, Bruner & Ross, 1976) is a term for temporary pedagogic support tailored to the learner's zone of proximal development (ZPD), a concept introduced to specify the gap between independent and supported performance. A key word to utilize is "self-efficacy" (Bandura, 1997), or the student's belief in his or her capacity to achieve tasks, and therefore exerts a strong influence on academic persistence. Another key idea, "growth mindset" (Dweck, 2006), further defines these terms by explaining the conviction that ability can be expressed through effort and not a fixed thinking pattern. Contrasted with summative evaluations aimed at outcome measurement are terms like "formative assessment" (Black & Wiliam, 1998) to describe ongoing assessments aimed at shaping instruction based on students' needs. Together, these terms represent the empirical direction of the field, exemplified in "cognitive load theory" (Sweller, 1988), which explains how working memory limitations affect

the acquisition of complicated information.

Though critics point to possible cultural biases in such constructions as ZPD (Rogoff, 2003), the terminology operationalizes broad psychological processes into observable teaching practices. Case study Educational psychology has many terminologies that can cause confusion because of overlapping meanings, subtle distinctions, or an intangible character.

Cases study

The next segment presents some often misunderstood terms:

Terminologies	Translation to arabic	Explanation
Psychosis vs. Neurosis	الذهان العصاب	الذهان :فقدان الاتصال بالواقع (مثل الهلوسة أو الأوهام في الفصام العصاب :اضطراب عاطفي دون فقدان الواقع (مثل القلق أو الاكتئاب).
Affect vs. Mood	الانفعال المزج	الانفعال : التعبير العاطفي الملاحظ لفترة قصيرة (مثل الابتسام أو البكاء) المزاج : حالة عاطفية طويلة الأمد (مثل الحزن المزمن في الاكتئاب).
Delusion vs. Hallucination	الوهم الهلوسة	الوهم : اعتقاد خاطئ ثابت (مثل "المخابرات تتجسس علي) الهلوسة : تجربة حسية دون منبه حقيقي (مثل سماع أصوات)
Obsession vs. Compulsion	الهوس القهر	الهوس : أفكار متطفلة غير مرغوب فيها (مثل الخوف من الجراثيم) القهر : سلوك متكرر لتخفيف القلق (مثل غسل اليدين باستمرار)
Projection vs. Displacement	الإسقاط الإزاحة	الإسقاط : نسب مشاعرك غير المقبولة للآخرين (مثل "هو يكرهني" بينما أنت من تكرهه) الإزاحة :تحويل المشاعر لهدف أقل تهديداً (مثل الصراخ على الكلب بعد يوم سيء في العمل)

Anxiety vs. Fear	القلق الخوف	القلق :توقع تهديد مستقبلي (عام وغير محدد) الخوف :استجابة لخطر حالي ومحدد
Ego vs Id (Freud's Model) Superego	الهو الأنأ نموذج فرويد الأنأ العليا	الهو :غرائز بدائية تبحث عن المتعة ("أريد هذا الآن) الأنأ :الوسيط العقلاني بين الهو والواقع ("لنكر بطريقة منطقية." الأنأ العليا :الضمير الأخلاقي ("هذا خطأ
Schizophrenia vs. Dissociative Identity Disorder	الفصام اضطراب الهوية التفريقي	الفصام :اضطراب في إدراك الواقع (هلوسة، تفكير غير منتظم) اضطراب الهوية التفريقي :كان يُسمى تعدد الشخصيات) وجود هويات منفصلة في شخص واحد.
Cognitive Dissonance vs. Confirmation Bias	التنافر المعرفي انحياز التأكيد	التنافر المعرفي :صراع داخلي عندما تتعارض المعتقدات مع الأفعال (مثل التدخين رغم معرفة أضراره) انحياز التأكيد :تفضيل المعلومات التي تؤكد معتقداتك الموجودة مسبقاً
Empathy vs. Sympathy	التعاطف العطف	التعاطف :الشعور مع الشخص (كما لو كنت مكانه) العطف :الشعور بالشفقة تجاه شخص (من دون مشاركته شعوره

Key psychological concepts—psychosis and neurosis, affect and mood, and other terminological distinctions—are compared.

This work employs psychologic and psychoanalytic terminology to discuss fundamental dichotomies, emphasizing their clinical, theoretical, and phenomenological distinctions. The concepts are examined through an in-depth analysis based on descriptive psychopathology, Freudian structural theory, and cognitive-behavioral models, with specific emphasis on their Arabic

translations and the nuanced disparities of their meanings.

1. Neurosis (العصب) vs. psychosis (الذهن) Psychosis

It is defined by a significant detachment from reality, frequently manifesting through hallucinations, including paranoid thoughts, and sensory distortions, such as auditory perceptions of voices that are not present, which are often linked to schizophrenia. Conversely, neurosis pertains to ineffective emotional reactions devoid of any alteration in the perception of reality, typically emerging as chronic anxiety or depressive feelings (Andreasen, 1984).

The Arabic terminology for psychosis reflects its derivational connection to the "dissolution of the mind" (ذهان), while "neurosis" (العصاب) derives from the idea of a "nervous disorder," reflecting its historical origin in neurology in the 19th century (Berrios, 1996).

2. Affect (الإنفعال) vs. Mood (المزج)

Affect describes observable and temporary expressions of emotion, for example, crying and laughter. Mood, in contrast, suggests a more persistent state of emotional existence, for example, dysthymia. While mood encompasses a more inclusive, culture-determined emotional baseline (Kleinman, 1988), the Arabic term suggests reactivity, which concurs with its application in the examination of temporary physiological reactions (Ekman, 1992).

3. Delusion (الوهم) vs. Hallucination (الهوسة).

Hallucinations are perceptual experiences that happen in the absence of any external stimuli, for example, hearing voices. Delusions, on the other hand, are strongly held untrue beliefs that remain in spite of disproving evidence, for instance, persecutory delusions.

While in Arabic, "وهم" is delusion, i.e., a false belief, "هوسة" is the term used for hallucination and is derived from a root meaning "to wander" or a feeling of sensory detachment. This distinction is clarified by Jaspers in 1963.

4. Compulsion (القهر) vs obsession (الهوس)

Compulsions are characterized by repetitive behaviors enacted in the effort to reduce anxiety, as exemplified by repetitive

handwashing. Obsessions, however, are marked by unwanted and disturbing thoughts, e.g., contaminations fears. The Arabic word for obsession, هوس, has historically been used to connote a type of "madness," while the word for compulsion, قهر, would imply coercion, reflecting the conflict of these behaviors with a person's idea of self. This is consistent with the characterizations in the (DSM-5 2013).

5. Projection (الاسقاط) rather than displacement (الازاحة)

One of Freud's defense mechanisms, projection, is the attribution of one's unacceptable feelings to others (e.g., accusing others of being aggressive). Displacement is the redirecting of feelings toward a less dangerous target, e.g., yelling at a spouse following frustration in the workplace. Whereas (displacement) implies "shifting" (Freud, 1894/1962), the Arabic literally implies "casting outward."

6. Fear (الخوف) vs Anxiety (القلق)

Anxiety, on the other hand, is a nonspecific, future-focused fear (e.g., generalized anxiety disorder), whereas fear is a response to a threat that is imminent (e.g., panic during a phobic encounter). The term anxiety in Arabic is derived from "restlessness," whereas fear is an archaic survival mechanism (Barlow, 2002).

7. In Freudian Theory (الهر), egotism () vs. id (الأنا العليا) The id, as theorists envisioned it, represents basic urges like libido, whereas the ego is a reality mediator and the superego entails internalized moral principles. In the Arabic translations, Freud's structural metaphors are preserved, where the "id" emphasizes the sense of anonymity, contrary to the "ego," which means concepts of selfhood (Bettelheim, 1982).

Recommendations

In view of the inconsistencies and conceptual ambiguities identified in translating complex psychopedagogical terminology, several recommendations can be formulated:

First of all, standardization Initiatives: Academic institutions, professional translators, and educational publishers should collaborate to develop standardized glossaries of psychopedagogical terms. This could minimize confusion and promote consistent use across curricula, research publications, and teacher-training programs. **Secondly, interdisciplinary Collaboration:** Translators should work closely with experts in psychology, education, and cognitive science to ensure that the translated terms reflect the latest theoretical and empirical developments in the field. **Then, Cultural and Conceptual Adaptation:** Translators should move beyond a strictly literal approach by considering the cultural and epistemological frameworks of the target audience, adapting terms where necessary to preserve both their functional and conceptual equivalence. **After that, Training and Capacity Building:** Translation programs in higher education should incorporate specialized modules on psychopedagogical translation, equipping future translators with the knowledge to handle such interdisciplinary terminology effectively. **Finally, Continuous Review:** Given the dynamic evolution of psychopedagogical research, translation practices and glossaries should be periodically reviewed and updated to reflect new concepts, theories, and culturally relevant interpretations.

Conclusion

This study has addressed the problematic variations in translating complex psychopedagogical terminologies from English into Arabic, highlighting both linguistic and conceptual challenges. Through comparative analysis, it has become evident that the lack of standardized equivalents, compounded by epistemological and cultural differences, has contributed to inconsistent and sometimes confusing translations.

In response to these issues, the research supports the hypotheses that terminological fragmentation reflects deeper cultural and theoretical divergences, and that greater clarity can be achieved through systematic standardization, interdisciplinary collaboration, and culturally sensitive adaptation. Ultimately, enhancing the accuracy and consistency of psychopedagogical terminology in Arabic will foster clearer communication, improve educational quality, and facilitate meaningful knowledge transfer across linguistic and cultural boundaries.

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